the riots and charges of conspiracy being made against the chief minister's office, Modi needed someone in the home ministry who would be totally faithful to him. Modi trusted very few individuals—Shah was the one politician he felt a certain comfort factor with. 'He was the eyes and ears of the chief minister,' is how one Gujarat bureaucrat describes Shah's role in that government.

It was during his tenure as home minister of Gujarat that Shah courted controversy. Between 2003 and 2007, there were a series of encounter killings in Gujarat in which several young Muslims were killed. Shah claimed they were 'terrorists', some of whom wanted to kill the chief minister, and that the killings were driven by a zero-tolerance policy towards terror. Human rights activists argued that many of the encounters were 'fake' and Shah was a 'Muslim killer'.

In 2010, Shah was arrested by the CBI and accused of killing a criminal, Sohrabuddin Sheikh, his wife Kauser Bi and their associate Tulsiram Prajapati, in a staged encounter. According to the CBI, Sheikh had been extorting money from marble traders in neighbouring Rajasthan. The traders complained to Shah, who reportedly got the state's Anti-Terrorism Squad to organize the killing. Several police officers were also arrested in the case.

Shah got bail three months after his arrest but was told he would have to leave Gujarat for fear that he would influence the investigation. For nearly two years, Shah stayed at Gujarat Bhavan in the national capital, away from his home state. 'What do you miss most?' I asked him. 'The khana,' he said with a hint of a smile. His wife had to come to live in Delhi with him to ensure that the *shudh* vegetarian Shah remained well fed—he liked his dal, *kadhi*, *khandwi* and Gujarati snacks.

Interestingly, on the day in September 2012 when Shah was finally allowed to return home, I was on the same flight with him, travelling to Ahmedabad. Dressed in his trademark kurta–pyjama and with a small bag in hand, he could have been mistaken for a small-time businessman. He was alone, no sidekicks by his side. But his spirit was undaunted.